THE SHATTERING

Session 14 — *Farewell, Flint*

Previously, aboard the BBC…

The bay still stank of blood and burnt coolant when the last of the space pirates stopped moving.

They had come aboard loud and proud, announcing themselves as the Corno Spezzato, every one of them wearing the regalia. Now they were meat on your deck plating.

You looted them where they fell. Salvage, sidearms, odds and ends, and twenty thousand credits by the time it was all counted out. But on each of the pirate captains you found something that didn't belong with the rest of it — a single card, sealed inside a high-tech vault built to hold exactly one thing.

Lor cracked the first vault open with her hacking. 5p0r3 opened the second by simply *reaching* into it, the way he reaches into anything that was made rather than born.

You expected credentials. Codes. A route, a name, a paymaster.

What you found were two cards drawn from a Deck of Many Things.

There was a discussion. It was short.

Killua drew.

The Serpent. The card chose its target on its own, and an ancient ethereal god-serpent sank its fangs into one of your own — marked for death inside a single day, with nothing in the universe able to undo it but a *wish*.

Killua did not hesitate. He reached across the echo and pulled Asra into the space between the serpent and its prey. His sister took the bite meant for someone else. Half of Killua's own being now carried a death-mark and a twenty-four hour clock.

Then he drew again.

The Wish. The single best card in the deck, pulled by a man who had no business being that lucky, and it came with exactly one casting. The answer was sitting right there in front of him. One word and the serpent's mark comes off his sister.

He did not use it on her.

He used it to fold time backward and draw both cards over again.

The bay lurched. The dead were the dead again. The vaults were sealed again. And Killua drew both cards at once.

The first card tore twenty bodies into existence out of nothing — living, breathing, blinking soldiers standing in the cargo bay, and all of them his.

The second card was **the Void**.

Killua was gone between one breath and the next. Not dead — *taken*. Body left standing, eyes empty, nobody home. His soul locked away somewhere none of you could see.

And then, almost before the silence could settle, something came back into that body.

Asra opened Killua's eyes and looked out at you.

The twin who threw herself away to save him is wearing him now.

You didn't leave him out there.

Aelyn and 5p0r3 both reached for their gods — two communions, two sets of answers — and between them they narrowed it down. Killua's soul is on **Echo**, in the Inner Rim. Southern hemisphere. That's as fine a point as the divine would put on it.

Then you turned to the ship.

You patched the BBC where the pirates had opened her, worked around the breach pod still buried in her hull like a tick, and got her stable enough to fly. The pirate dead went into an airlock chamber left open to vacuum — cold storage, and a problem for later.

It was in the handling of those bodies that you learned something about the Corno Spezzato that none of you asked to know. Every man among them had been gelded. Cut, cauterized, and in most cases fitted with cybernetic replacements.

5p0r3 harvested the entire collection.

He still has them.

Straleon. Port Vesper.

You were barely down the ramp when Ghost started shouting.

He'd registered it the moment you made planetfall — Luminous disciples close, a temple closer, and his own data stores running hot. He was overdue. He needed communion, and he needed you to get him to it *now*.

You met the dock master first. **Bix.** Five thousand credits to make the BBC whole again, three to four days in the cradle, payable when you come back for her.

Asra leaned on the counter and turned something on that Killua never had. Bix went pink to the ears and allowed as how she'd see what she could do about that price.

Then the Church came to collect you. A Dragonborn disciple named **Eska**, a sand skiff idling at the edge of the port, and a long crossing out into the deadlands of Straleon toward the temple that stands in them.

Hymfall.

The ride was quiet. Except for Ghost.

The disciples of the Lux Codicants were waiting for you at the temple gates, and the welcome turned into an unmasking before any of you had brushed the dust off.

They said, plainly, in front of everyone, that Aelyn and Ghost were not what they had let you believe. Cornered, the two of them gave up a piece of it — that both of them have been intertwined, this whole time, with an ancient god-like being.

Then the Codicants turned to Flint.

They called him the **Flesh Cipher**.

The doctrine, as they gave it: if the Luminous Engine is the recorder of all time and all history, then the Flesh Cipher is the one who transcribes those recordings. Born once every hundred years or so. Once, and then not again for a lifetime.

The Archcodicant laid the rest of it out. **Saturiba** — the man who raised Flint on Fellwinter, his mentor, his father in every way that counted — had suspected what Flint was, and had spent all those years quietly mentoring him toward it.

And it was the reason, the Archcodicant said, that Ghost and Aelyn ever saved Flint's life at all. They had been able to see it in him too.

To ascend into it fully, Flint would have to face the **Trials of the Whole** — and you would have to face them with him.

To become whole.

You agreed.

THE TRIALS OF THE WHOLE

Four pillars of what it is to be a living thing in this universe. You did not fight them. You stood inside a memory of each one and bore witness.

I. Love and Fellowship.

The *Codex* — the BBC under her old name, before any of you knew her. Lor's first crew, alive and together, in a moment of plain love and easy fellowship. Handed back to be seen again.

II. Sacrifice.

Aurelian. The clone chambers where the Syralith are grown, and where Killua and Asra were made.

The twins, infants, suspended in a tube while scientists argued over them — one embryo had split into two, which was not supposed to be possible. The word they kept using was *abominations*. Days of deliberation. A few insisted it was a sign from the heavens, a good omen. Most concluded both of them had to be terminated.

Not long after the talk turned to termination, Asra — on instinct, on reflex, with no idea what she was doing — threw everything she had through her connection to the echo and shifted permanently into echo form.

To everyone watching, she simply stopped existing. As though she had aborted herself.

She did it so her brother would live. The scientists couldn't explain the vanishing, so they called it a miracle, and they called Killua a chosen one, and they let him live.

III. Perseverance.

5p0r3, adrift in open black for more than five hundred years, holding on to nothing but the hope that someday he would get to *live* — until the research vessel he clung to fell out of the dark and broke itself against Velthros, where he found all of you, and finally got it.

IV. Death and Life.

Flint and Aelyn told this one between them.

Fellwinter. Saturiba taking a boy under his wing and teaching him magic, mechanics, hacking — everything Flint knows, Saturiba put there. And then Saturiba's past caught him up. Fey Court agents came for him. Everyone believed he was murdered.

He wasn't. He was *taken*.

Flint was the one who was murdered, in that same moment, by those same agents.

And by whatever serendipity runs this galaxy, Aelyn was on Fellwinter at the time, running a job for the Myriad. She and Ghost came across Flint's body. They could tell there was something in him worth keeping. They grafted on the arcano-mechanical arm, channeled the Luminous Engine through it, and brought him back.

Death. And then life.

THE COMMUNION

You came back to the temple proper. The Codicants confirmed you had passed, and that Flint would be granted the **Missing Chapter** — the relic that would make the Flesh Cipher whole.

Before any of that could happen, Ghost broke.

He caromed around the chamber, colliding with pillars and disciples alike, announcing that his data stores had hit critical mass. He needed the **Radiant Tabernacle**. He needed communion, and he needed it immediately.

The Codicants scrambled and hauled in the **Tabernacle Throne** — the seat that lets Ghost take the whole crushing weight of his memory and compress it down into the Sacrament.

Then they argued over who would be allowed to receive it. The honor went to **Elo the Thrice**, who had taken the sacrament once before, and who was judged the most capable and the most ready on such short notice.

She slid beneath the Radiant Tabernacle and bared her chest to the underside of Ghost.

He compressed the entirety of his data into a single cube of divine knowledge, sheathed in neurotropic technoplasm, and set it down onto her.

The Codicants wept and cheered. Another mote of knowledge added to the repository.

THE MISSING CHAPTER

You gathered around Flint.

Ghost explained that the Missing Chapter was never a text. It was a piece of Flint himself.

To every other eye in that room it looked like a page torn from a tome. To Flint it was flesh. Tubular. And he put it together fast — this was part of him, cut away from him at birth, without his consent and without his knowledge.

It had been kept all this time inside another artifact entirely: the **Hood of Wisdom**.

It was his foreskin. And it could only be rejoined to him through religious ceremony, performed with Ghost.

The two of them joined forms. Flint inserted himself into Ghost's holy orifice, and the Hood of Wisdom was fused back onto him.

The Flesh Cipher was whole again.

And Flint ascended.

His eyes kindled with radiant light. Every encrypted glyph and rune crawling across the ceiling and walls of Hymfall came unscrambled at once — resolving into clean, readable images of events and people long past, and *continuing* to write themselves into the stone in real time as the seconds went by.

The all-reading transcriber of the Luminous Engine.

THE FAREWELL

The Archcodicant told him what came next. Flint's place is with the Lux Codicants now — part of the whole grand design of the Luminous Church, to record history and tell it true to every generation that comes after.

You said your goodbyes one at a time. Heartfelt. Short.

Two things followed you out the door.

The first was the Archcodicant's charge. Flint's first task as Flesh Cipher is to find his old master. **Saturiba is still missing** — and he is to be brought back into the church.

The second was Ghost's parting gift. He told Flint that he is now in sync with the arcano-mechanical third arm — and that this synchronization can, at any moment either of them chooses, pull Flint to the party or the party to Flint.

If your paths ever need to cross again, they can.

Eska loaded what was left of HOC.2a back onto his sand skiff and turned it around, out of the deadlands, toward the city of **Chromehymn**.

Killua's soul is on Echo. Asra is wearing his body. Twenty soldiers you never asked for are standing around waiting for orders. There are five thousand credits owed at Port Vesper and a ship in pieces to pay them with.

And Flint is behind you, reading the walls.